

INTO THE JAZZ AGE

During the Roaring Twenties women's clothes became a powerful expression of the modernist approach to all forms of art. Many old attitudes were swept away by World War I, and with them the long skirts and waist-cinching corsetry of the early 1900s. Such constrictions were unsuited to the vital, active wartime roles women took as land-workers, drivers, and machine-operators. By the 1920s more women could vote, and more entered the professions. They drove, smoked, drank cocktails, and worshipped screen stars such as Clara Bow. Dress became relaxed and strikingly simple.

One key aspect of the modern woman's look was *pour le sport*. Clothes developed for physical activity left their mark on fashion, while sport itself helped to achieve the stovepipe silhouette. Women hankered after the image of *La Garçonne* (Bachelor Girl or Tomboy) from the eponymous 1922 novel by Victor Margueritte. Hair was bobbed or cut into the "Eton crop" and hugged by clothes, waists abandoned or dropped to the hips, and chests flattened.

Believing that clothes should be casual and easy to wear, and borrowing from men's garments and sports and leisure fabrics, Coco Chanel and Jean Patou took a fashion lead. Their plain sweaters, short, pleated skirts (hemlines rose to the knees by the mid-1920s), and use of soft wool jerseys allowed free movement and won immediate international success. Everyday clothes featured unstructured jackets, hip-length sweaters, and simple blouses and skirts. By night, drop-waisted, full-hemmed dresses allowed flappers another important freedom – to dance the night away at jazz clubs.

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Fashion is not something that exists in dresses only. Fashion is in the sky, in the street, fashion has to do with ideas, the way we live, what is happening.

COCO CHANEL

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◀ POUR LE SPORT

Models seated in the back of a luxury yacht showcase the fashion of the day with linen jackets, pleated skirts, and berets or cloche hats.

